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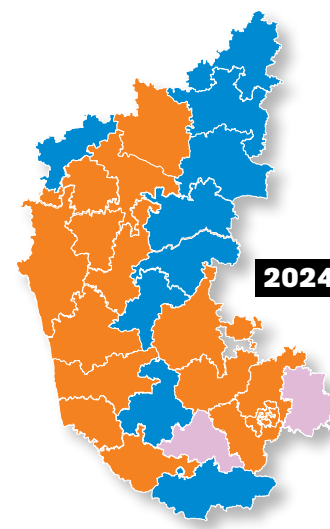


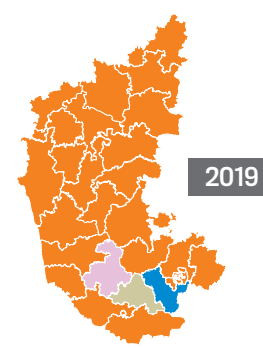
FAILED OPTIMISM? Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi and CM Siddaramaiah in Shimoga, May 2

WIN SOME, LOSE SOME

The Congress makes a dent in the BJP's tally, but its dwindling Vokkaliga support should be cause for alarm

By **Ajay Sukumaran**





In late April, amid the high-voltage campaigning leading up to the first phase of the Lok Sabha election in Karnataka on April 26, Chief Minister Siddaramaiah was thrilled to receive a unique souvenir from a law student in the state's Arsikere region. Strung together into a garland were the 'zero fare' bus tickets she had collected since bus travel was made free for women in Karnataka by the Siddaramaiah government after taking office last year. The Congress's welfare schemes have been a hit, especially among women, and it was this goodwill that the party was counting on for a double-digit haul in the Lok Sabha polls.

The jury is still out on whether these welfare schemes paid off. The Congress's vote share has risen significantly but the Karnataka result hasn't brought much